

AI using water is softening us up to the idea scarcity

Posted by u/sam_emvy • • 0 points • 16 comments

So AI uses a lot of water per question/prompt, but so does anything needing cooling. It's usually sent out, cooled, and recirculated back again. Why can't that same principle be done here? I personally haven't found a logical reason that makes any sense.

I have a feeling water isn't actually being "used up", but instead this is being used as the first step to create the idea that water is becoming scarce. More so, I've also heard growing up that the next major war would be over control of water, and maybe this is a launch pad for justifying that idea later.

Not sure, could be wrong, but not a thing about it makes sense so far, and I work with systems that use circulating water cooled through heat exchanging equipment. I've worked on everything from CPU's to industrial and refining equipment. None of them have a limitation in place to justify saying the water is just "gone".

That's all I go so far.

Comments

u/Sas_fruit • 1 points • 2026-01-16 17:51 UTC

I am watching a video where it talks about from an article that glass scarcity is coming

u/thefiglord • 1 points • 2026-01-13 16:14 UTC

a big nope - they are going to put them in space 24x7 sun for power and cooling is free and no permits needed

u/EdwardTheAlbanian • 1 points • 2026-01-14 01:16 UTC

How?

u/jackfruitjunkie • 2 points • 2026-01-13 09:56 UTC

They tell us to conserve water or skip a shower on the news, then play a Burger King ad a minute later, ignoring that a single beef burger costs over 600 gallons of water.

Data from May 2025 shows that while AI used about 18 billion liters of water, dairy production

consumes a staggering 4.5 trillion. Since then, with closed-loop cooling tech, AI is also getting more efficient.

The real conspiracy: We grow enough food to feed 10 billion people, yet 800 million starve because we funnel 40% of our grain into livestock.

We use 80% of our land on livestock animals that provide less than 20% of our calories. Data centers aren't eating up our land and resources, animal ag is, and it's even heavily subsidized by the US govt.

u/MoistAttitude • 2 points • 2026-01-13 07:26 UTC

One single A4 sheet of paper takes [up to 13 L of water](<https://research.utwente.nl/en/publications/the-green-and-blue-water-footprint-of-paper-products-methodologic/#:~:text=The%20water%20footprint%20of%20printing,litres%20for%20an%20A4%20sheet>) to produce. A figure many times higher than an AI image prompt. The reported figures of AI water usage is sensationalized. If you had a pulp mill in your neighbourhood you would see far more drastic effects on the water supply.

The problem is these centers are drawing on a supply in commercial areas for what is essentially an industrial operation.

u/Truthsurge_24 • 4 points • 2026-01-13 05:36 UTC

well, luckily for us.. the water cant go anywhere, it all stays on earth or in the clouds, and we have the ability to clean it and use it again.. most water from the taps is recycled

u/MoistAttitude • 2 points • 2026-01-13 07:56 UTC

This is completely ignorant. If you pump water out of rivers and water tables too fast, [aquifers will literally collapse](<https://www.wired.com/story/the-ongoing-collapse-of-the-worlds-aquifers/>) and *never come back again*. Understand that fresh water is a finite resource, especially if you're not right beside a lake or river.

u/AnxietyTurbulent4861 • 2 points • 2026-01-13 05:02 UTC

AI poisons the water, why?

u/pseudonym7083 • 2 points • 2026-01-13 06:55 UTC

It probably has a coolant component in it, like the motor in a car.

u/EdwardTheAlbanian • 1 points • 2026-01-14 01:17 UTC

It does not

u/AnxietyTurbulent4861 • 1 points • 2026-01-13 07:05 UTC

ooh, thanks

u/Agreeable_Manner2848 • 3 points • 2026-01-13 04:46 UTC

when AI uses water, its not being obliterated out of this world, many AI systems especially where they can utilize the heat for offices or community management have closed water ecosystems. Otherwise the data centers "using" tons of water in most of the continental USA and Asia are in land, so the lost water is simply evaporating and will return mostly in the same large general area. This one isn't a conspiracy of that nature, its overflow and extreme raising awareness gone hay wire. Data Centers utilize, not use and obliterate, water, and people in the we've moved past religion/posterization/how we act is destroying the world to charity/raise awareness/ what we consume is destroying the world. They saw a huge number, related to water, and assumed it would be a good talking point.

You really wanna understand water fuckery and as a caveat I'm not big on believing the "natives" are stewards of the land, but this kind of incompetence, or planned poisoning is intense:

[<https://www.grandcanyontrust.org/blog/whats-uranium-mine-near-grand-canyon/>]

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u/Binarydemons • 4 points • 2026-01-13 04:31 UTC

I thought AI was using ddr5 to soften us up to the idea of scarcity.

u/HappyKrud • 3 points • 2026-01-13 04:29 UTC

This could be why the US is threatening Canada. Canada holds the most fresh water out of any countries if I recall correctly while most big AI companies are American. If Canada becomes more anti-AI, it's very likely America will do their imperial shuffle over there.

u/whothennow24 • -3 points • 2026-01-13 04:59 UTC

Water literally falls from the sky. No need to go to war over it.

u/HappyKrud • 5 points • 2026-01-13 05:04 UTC

You'd think that but the CEO of Nestle, a company which drains water from a lot of vulnerable communities, has said water is not a human right. These are people that are close to the American government.

u/bl0oc • 1 points • 2026-01-13 11:01 UTC

Water doesn't just disappear, how quickly and where it gets replenished is the question.

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2026-01-13 04:21 UTC

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